

to work his way around the Confederate position and cut its supply line through Tennessee. He dug a canal to move troop transports downstream of the island and also had two ironclads slip past the island's batteries under cover of darkness. With this support, his troops were able to cross the river to the Tennessee shore. Surrounded and outnumbered, the island garrison surrendered on April 8.

## **Confederate success**

The chief remaining obstacle between the Union gunboats and their destination Memphis was Fort Pillow, which the gunboats started to bombard in May. Desperate to defend Memphis, the Confederates sent eight cottonclad rams north, leaving New Orleans seriously short of naval defense. On May 10, the cottonclads, commanded by James Montgomery, inflicted a sharp reverse on the Union flotilla at Fort Pillow. They pressed through Union gunfire to ram the ironclads USS *Mound City* and USS *Cincinatti*, both of which sank.